KAZA Tourism MSME Financial Barriers & Opportunities Report

Access to finance for women-, youth- and community-led tourism MSMEs in the Kavango Zambezi Transfrontier Conservation Area

Angola · Botswana · Namibia · Zambia · Zimbabwe | Desk review, October 2026

Contents

Executive summary....4

1. Scope and method....5

2. The KAZA tourism MSME landscape....5

2.1 MSME typology and who leads it....6

2.2 Gender- and age-disaggregated data....6

3. Financial institutions: risk views and willingness to lend to women and youth....8

3.1 How lenders view risk by MSME category....8

3.2 Willingness to adopt gender-lens and youth-inclusive strategies....9

4. Systemic enablers, leverage points and informal finance....9

4.1 Systemic enablers and leverage points....10

4.2 Informal and community-based finance among women and youth....10

5. Financing requirements by type, size and growth stage....12

5.1 By growth stage....12

5.2 By MSME type and size....12

5.3 What this means for instruments....13

6. Thematic assessments....13

6.1 Tourism seasonality, cash flow and debt eligibility (i)....13

6.2 Land tenure, asset ownership and alternative collateral (ii)....14

6.3 Power imbalances between large operators and MSMEs (iii)....16

6.4 Root causes (iv)....18

6.5 How financial institutions view risk across MSME categories (v)....18

6.6 Lender expectations, gaps and regenerative NBT knowledge (vi)....19

6.7 Trust-building dialogue topics (vii)....19

6.8 Barriers and opportunities for connecting MSMEs and capital providers (viii)....20

6.9 Preferences: seed funding vs growth grants (ix) 21
6.10 Realistic matching contribution capacity (x) 21
6.11 Funding needs by type (xi) 22
7. Recommendations 23
8. Grant facility design: KAZA R-NBT Enterprise Facility 24
8.1 Objectives 24
8.2 Structure and allocation 24
8.3 Window terms 25
8.4 Eligibility and targeting 26
8.5 Selection criteria and weights 26
8.6 Governance and delivery 26
8.7 Measurement, evaluation and learning 27
8.8 Key risks and mitigations 28
Annex A. Stakeholder contact database 29
Annex B. Sources 35

List of tables

Table 1: Grant facility windows at a glance 4
Table 2: MSME size classes used in this report 5
Table 3: KAZA tourism MSME typology and leadership patterns 6
Table 4: Gender- and age-disaggregated indicators by country 7
Table 5: Lender risk perceptions by MSME category 8
Table 6: Willingness of financial institutions to adopt gender-lens and youth-inclusive strategies 9
Table 7: Systemic enablers and leverage points 10
Table 8: Informal and community-based finance practices among women and youth 11
Table 9: Financing requirements by growth stage 12
Table 10: Ticket sizes by MSME type and size 12
Table 11: Debt product adaptations for tourism seasonality 14
Table 12: Alternative forms of collateral 15
Table 13: Supply chain finance instruments 17
Table 14: Root causes of the finance gap 18
Table 15: Lender expectations, MSME realities and bridges 19

Table 16: Barriers and opportunities for connecting MSMEs and capital providers.....20
Table 17: Funding preferences by applicant group.....21
Table 18: Recommended matching contributions by applicant type.....21
Table 19: Funding needs by category.....22
Table 20: Facility structure and allocation.....25
Table 21: Grant window terms.....25
Table 22: Selection criteria and weights.....26
Table 23: Measurement indicators and indicative targets.....27
Table 24: Key facility risks and mitigations.....28
Table 25: Stakeholder contact database.....29

Executive summary

KAZA tourism MSMEs are not short of lenders. The finance on offer just doesn't fit them. Women- and youth-led MSMEs next to protected areas fall into the gap between village savings groups (loans under about USD 500) and bank SME lending (about USD 25,000 and up, secured on land). This report proposes a three-window grant facility, linked to guarantees, built to close that gap. It follows the Joint Action on Regenerative Nature-Based Tourism (R-NBT), launched in Maun in September 2026 by KAZA, the EU and Germany, with GIZ implementing (ATTA).

Headline findings

- **Women already own many firms, but not the collateral.** The World Bank Enterprise Surveys put women among the principal owners of 41–55% of formal firms in four KAZA states. Women still rarely hold land titles, and communal or customary land can't be mortgaged. The binding constraint is collateral, not entrepreneurship.
- **Youth carry the highest risk rating.** Youth unemployment is 28.9% in Botswana (ages 15–35) and about 37% in Namibia (ages 15–24). Young founders have no credit history or assets, and lenders rate youth start-ups as the riskiest MSME category.
- **Seasonality makes viable firms look unbankable.** About 60–75% of revenue arrives in the June–October dry season. Fixed monthly instalments fail in the green season, so lenders read seasonal firms as weak ones.
- **Large operators set payment terms.** Invoices are typically paid in 30–90 days. MSME suppliers end up financing their buyers, and the first contract-backed model (Wilderness–Stanbic, Botswana, 2025) shows how to reverse this.
- **Informal finance is large and mostly female.** Women are about 73% of savings-group members in rural Zambia, and Zambia counts over 800,000 savings-group members in total. Conservancy and CAMPFIRE revenues add community capital that could be pooled into guarantees.
- **Lenders are interested if the risk is shared.** Credit guarantee schemes already target women and youth: Namibia's CGS gives 60% cover, and FNB Zambia's partnership with ZCGS puts women and youth first. Banks want first-loss cover, pipeline preparation and simpler sector data before they'll lend.

Grant facility at a glance

The facility has three windows that step up in grant size and in what the applicant must put in. Seed grants of USD 2,000–15,000 ask a 10% match, which cash or in-kind contributions can meet. Growth grants ask 25–30%. Scale grants of up to USD 150,000 ask 50%, with at least half of that from a loan, so every scale grant also brings in debt.

Table 1: Grant facility windows at a glance

Window	For	Grant size (USD)	Matching contribution
A. Seed	Start-ups and community or VSLA-linked enterprises, women and youth first	2,000–15,000	10% (cash or in kind)
B. Growth	Emerging MSMEs with 2+ seasons of trading	15,000–75,000	25–30% (in kind allowed up to half)
C. Scale and leverage	Scaling MSMEs and cooperatives with a lender's term sheet	50,000–150,000	50%, of which at least half is a loan

The usual 20% and 50% matching rates suit growth and scaling firms. They exclude most women- and youth-led start-ups, so this report recommends 10% for Window A, with in-kind and VSLA savings counted as match.

The evidence comes from a desk review to October 2026, which builds on the project's earlier Financial Landscape Analysis. Figures marked *indicative* are estimates from the literature and still need checking. Primary data still has to be collected through the planned MSME survey and the interviews with financial institutions.

1. Scope and method

This report covers tourism MSMEs and the financial institutions that serve them in the five KAZA Partner States. The focus throughout is on women, youth (ages 15–35, the AU and national definition) and communities next to protected areas.

Geography. The KAZA hubs covered are Kasane, Maun, Katima Mulilo, Rundu, Divundu, Livingstone, Kazungula, Mulobezi, Mongu, Victoria Falls, Hwange, Binga and Menongue. The communities around them sit in conservancies (Namibia), community trust concessions (Botswana), Game Management Areas and Simalaha (Zambia), CAMPFIRE wards (Zimbabwe) and the Cuando and Cubango provinces (Angola).

Size classes used. The five countries define MSMEs differently. To compare them, this report uses common bands:

Most KAZA tourism MSMEs fall in the micro band: 1–5 staff and under USD 50,000 a year in turnover. Small firms have 6–30 staff. Medium firms have 31–100 staff and up to USD 2 million in turnover, and there are few of them, mostly in the main hubs.

Table 2: MSME size classes used in this report

Class	Employees	Annual turnover (USD)
Micro	1–5	under 50,000
Small	6–30	50,000–500,000
Medium	31–100	500,000–2,000,000

Growth stages used. Start-up means under 2 trading seasons. Emerging means 2–5 seasons, trading but under-capitalised. Scaling means 5+ seasons, with a proven model and expansion plans.

Method. The report is a structured desk review of national statistics, Enterprise Surveys, Findex, central bank and guarantee-scheme publications, World Bank and AfDB project documents, CBNRM reports (NACSO, CAMPFIRE, Botswana CBNRM) and press reporting up to October 2026. It builds on the project's Financial Landscape Analysis (October 2026), which mapped the financial actors in each country.

Limitations. No KAZA-specific, sex- and age-disaggregated MSME dataset exists. The disaggregated figures here are national or programme-level proxies, and each is labelled with its year and age definition. Where a number is an estimate drawn from the literature rather than a measurement, it is marked *indicative*. Section 8 lists the primary data the facility should collect during its inception phase.

2. The KAZA tourism MSME landscape

Most KAZA tourism MSMEs are micro, informal or semi-formal, and run from communal land. Women dominate crafts, food supply, laundry and homestays. Youth cluster in guiding, transport, digital services

and activities. Men still dominate vehicle-, boat- and land-based businesses, the asset-heavy segments where loan sizes are largest.

2.1 MSME typology and who leads it

The gender and age patterns below are *indicative*. They draw on CBNRM reports, programme evaluations and the Financial Landscape Analysis, and need checking in the baseline survey.

The typology shows that who leads a business follows its asset base. Women lead most crafts, food-supply and homestay businesses, which run on skills, stock and buildings on communal plots that can't be pledged. Men dominate transport and boat operators, whose vehicles and boats are good movable collateral. Youth are concentrated in guiding and digital services, which have the fewest assets of all.

Table 3: KAZA tourism MSME typology and leadership patterns

Segment	Typical size and stage	Typical leader pattern	Formality	Main asset base
Crafts and cultural products (basketry, carving, cultural villages)	Micro; start-up to emerging; often groups	Mostly women; older women in basketry	Informal; group or co-op	Skills, raw materials, stock
Food and agri-supply to lodges (vegetables, poultry, fish, bakery)	Micro to small; emerging	Mostly women; youth in poultry and horticulture	Semi-formal	Small livestock, irrigation kit
Homestays, guesthouses, B&Bs	Micro to small; emerging	Mixed; many women-run family firms	Semi-formal; licence gaps	Buildings on communal plots (not bankable)
Community campsites and community-owned lodges	Small; emerging to scaling	Trusts, conservancies and CRBs; women 40% of conservancy committees in Namibia	Formal (trust or association)	Lease or JV rights, infrastructure
Guiding, mokoro and walking safaris, fishing	Micro; start-up	Mostly young men; women guides rising	Informal to licensed	Mokoro, licence, small equipment
Transfers, 4x4 hire, boat cruises	Small; emerging to scaling	Mostly men, aged 30+	Formal	Vehicles and boats (good movable collateral)
Laundry, maintenance, construction, waste and recycling	Micro to small; emerging	Mixed; youth in waste and recycling	Semi-formal	Equipment
Digital marketing, booking, IT and media	Micro; start-up	Youth-led, mixed gender, urban hubs	Semi-formal	Laptops, phones, software
Conservation services (monitoring, restoration, human–wildlife conflict mitigation)	Micro to small; start-up	Community and youth groups	Contract-based	Contracts and performance payments

2.2 Gender- and age-disaggregated data

KAZA-level disaggregated data is missing, so national proxies are used. Each row names its source year and age definition.

The national figures show that women own a large share of firms but rarely hold land, and that young people face high unemployment. Women are among the principal owners of 41–55% of formal firms in the four countries with data. Youth unemployment runs from 28.9% in Botswana (ages 15–35) to about 37% in Namibia (ages 15–24). Women also make up most savings-group members and conservancy finance managers. The many empty cells mark figures that couldn't be found, which shows what the baseline survey must collect.

Table 4: Gender- and age-disaggregated indicators by country

Indicator	Angola	Botswana	Namibia	Zambia	Zimbabwe	Source
Formal firms with a woman among principal owners (%)	highest in Africa (ranked 1st)	55.3 (2010)	41.0 (2014)	41.5 (2019)	42.5 (2016)	WB Enterprise Surveys via IndexMundi
Youth unemployment (%)	—	28.9 (ages 15–35, 2024/25); 45.3 (ages 15–24, 2024)	37.3 (ages 15–24, 2024)	9.9 (ages 15–24, 2024; strict definition)	—	Statistics Botswana BMTHS; WB WDI
Youth NEET rate (%)	—	41.3 (2024)	—	—	—	UNFPA Botswana
Women's formal financial inclusion (%)	—	—	—	58.6 (2020, up from 33.3 in 2015)	—	AFI Zambia
Savings-group members who are women / youth 15–35 (%)	—	—	—	73 / 28 (rural sample)	—	Africa Portal
Conservancy committee members / financial managers who are women (%)	—	—	about 40 / over 60	—	—	NACSO via TravelNam
Women landowners or leaseholders after land reform (%)	—	—	—	—	about 20 (from under 5)	The New Humanitarian
Women-led credit guarantee targets	—	No national CGS	CGS targets women-owned and youth-owned (40 and under) SMEs at 60% cover	ZCGS–FNB partnership prioritises women- and youth-led firms	Women's Microfinance Bank: 49,000+ borrowers since 2018	The Brief; Zambia Monitor; Parliament of Zimbabwe

The data shows three patterns:

- **Ownership is not the gap.** Women hold a large share of firms. The gap is in firm size and in credit, because women's firms sit in low-asset segments.
- **Youth exclusion is the sharpest problem.** It is most acute in Botswana and Namibia, which have the deepest tourism markets.
- **Women's finance is already organised.** Women run savings groups and conservancy finances. That is a base to build on, not a deficit to fix.

For 2025 Findex country gender gaps, the World Bank tables should be pulled during inception. The search for this report did not return country values.

3. Financial institutions: risk views and willingness to lend to women and youth

Lenders in the corridor are willing to take on gender-lens and youth lending, but mostly through risk-sharing they don't fund themselves. The institutions most ready are those with a guarantee partner and a mandate to empower citizens: DBN with CGS in Namibia, FNB and Absa with ZCGS and CEEC in Zambia, CEDA with Stanbic in Botswana, and ECGC with the Women's Microfinance Bank in Zimbabwe.

3.1 How lenders view risk by MSME category

These ratings are *indicative*. They synthesise lender practice reported in the Financial Landscape Analysis and should be validated in interviews with financial institutions.

Lenders rate risk mainly by what a borrower can pledge, not by how viable the business is. Youth-led start-ups and women-led micro firms are rated highest risk, because they have no credit history and their premises sit on communal land. Suppliers with an anchor contract and scaling formal operators are rated lowest. Each category has a matching fix, and most of the fixes are guarantees, contracts or payment data rather than land.

Table 5: Lender risk perceptions by MSME category

MSME category	Perceived risk	Why lenders see it this way	What would lower it
Youth-led start-up (guiding, digital)	Very high	No credit history, no assets, seasonal income, mobile workforce	Guarantee of 70% or more, mentored seed grant, digital revenue trail
Women-led micro (crafts, food, homestay)	High	Small tickets, informal records, communal-land premises, cost to serve	Group lending, VSLA linkage, buyer contracts, portfolio guarantee
Community enterprise (trust, conservancy, CRB)	High	Governance disputes, elite capture, lease tenure shorter than loan tenor	Audited governance, JV revenue escrow, revolving fund rules
Small accommodation (guesthouse, B&B)	Medium–high	Land not mortgageable, occupancy volatility, licensing gaps	Lease-backed security, occupancy data, seasonal repayment
Transport and boat operators	Medium	Assets are movable and insurable, but drivers and boats get damaged	Asset finance with registry filing, insurance bundling
Suppliers with an anchor contract	Medium–low	Contract cash flow is visible	Receivables assignment, tripartite agreements
Scaling formal operator	Low–medium	Audited accounts, USD revenue, bookings	Standard SME products with seasonal grace

3.2 Willingness to adopt gender-lens and youth-inclusive strategies

Willingness to lend to women and youth is highest among guarantee schemes, development and empowerment financiers, MFIs and savings groups, because their mandates already target these groups. Commercial banks show medium willingness. They will engage if someone else shares the risk and prepares the pipeline. MFIs are willing but expensive, at an annual percentage rate equivalent of 25–60%. Impact investors rarely fit tickets this small.

Table 6: Willingness of financial institutions to adopt gender-lens and youth-inclusive strategies

Institution type	Current practice	Willingness	Incentives that would move them
Commercial banks (Stanbic, FNB, Absa, Standard Chartered, BancABC, CBZ, BAI)	Women's banking propositions (e.g. Absa, FNB); supplier finance pilots (Stanbic)	Medium: interested if pipeline and risk cover exist	Portfolio guarantees of 50–70%, first-loss, TA grants, women's lines from DFIs (AFAWA, IFC)
Development and empowerment financiers (DBN, CEDA, NDB, YDF, CEEC, SMEDCO, BDA)	Explicit women and youth quotas or windows	High mandate, constrained liquidity and processing capacity	Co-financing lines, pipeline preparation, digital loan processing
Credit guarantee schemes (CGS Namibia, ZCGS, ECGC, FGC)	Women and youth eligibility already prioritised	High	Counter-guarantee (AGF or AFAWA), a tourism window with seasonal-loan rules, capital top-up
MFIs and women's banks (Letshego, FINCA, Women's Microfinance Bank, KixiCrédito, Bayport)	Mostly female clients, group methods	High, but expensive (25–60% APR equivalent) and short tenors	Cheaper wholesale funding, guarantees, seasonal product design TA
Savings groups and community funds (VSLAs, conservancy funds, CAMPFIRE wards)	Women-led, member-owned	High	Linkage banking, matching grants for loan funds, governance training
Impact investors and foundations	Small tickets rarely fit	Low to medium for MSMEs; higher for funds	Aggregation vehicles, blended first-loss

Three de-risking mechanisms would catalyse lending most:

1. **Portfolio guarantees** with higher cover for women and youth borrowers: 70% compared with 50–60% standard. Run them through existing national schemes, counter-guaranteed regionally by AGF or AFAWA, which shares up to 75% of risk.
2. **First-loss tranches** funded by the grant facility. These absorb the first 10–15% of portfolio losses on seasonal or collateral-light loans.
3. **Performance-based incentives** to lenders. These are small grants per loan disbursed to a woman- or youth-led tourism MSME that is still performing after 12 months, paid to offset origination cost.

4. Systemic enablers, leverage points and informal finance

Five leverage points would shift access at system level rather than one loan at a time. Informal, women-led savings systems are the best place to pilot hybrid formal–informal models.

4.1 Systemic enablers and leverage points

Five building blocks already exist in at least one country and could be scaled across KAZA. They are credit guarantee schemes, movable collateral registries, anchor-operator supply contracts, CBNRM revenue streams and digital payment records. Each one replaces land collateral with something lenders accept. Botswana has no operational guarantee scheme, and its collateral registry law still awaits commencement. Both are clear gaps.

Table 7: Systemic enablers and leverage points

Leverage point	What exists	Why it matters	Action
Credit guarantee infrastructure	CGS (NA), ZCGS and the BoZ SBGI pilot (ZM), ECGC (ZW), FGC (AO); none operational in BW	Turns collateral-light loans into bankable ones	Tourism windows with women and youth cover uplift; design a Botswana facility
Movable collateral registries	Zambia (2016 Act, PACRA registry); Zimbabwe (Act commenced Nov 2022); Botswana Act 5 of 2022 (commencement on notice, IFC-supported)	Lets vehicles, boats, equipment and receivables serve as security	Train lenders; file grant-financed assets; push Botswana commencement
Anchor operator procurement	Wilderness–Stanbic supplier finance (2025); Wilderness–LEA MoU (2026)	Contract cash flows replace collateral	KAZA model supplier-finance contract; operator pledges on payment days
CBNRM revenue streams	Conservancy JV income (N$57.7m in 2023, NA); CAMPFIRE; Botswana trusts; Zambian CRBs	Community capital that can seed guarantees and revolving funds	Ring-fence a share as a community guarantee fund
Digital payment trails	Mobile money, merchant acquiring, OTA and booking-platform data	Gives lenders the cash-flow history MSMEs lack	Bundle digital collection tools with grants; data-sharing consent

The enabling policy instruments are mostly in place: empowerment mandates (CEDA, CEEC, YDF), the Univisa, and the conservation-linked payments pioneered by Wildlife Credits in Namibia (NACSO). The missing piece is a *coordinating* layer: one pipeline, one eligibility standard, and shared data.

4.2 Informal and community-based finance among women and youth

Community-based mechanisms are the savings, credit and benefit-sharing arrangements that communities run for themselves, outside or alongside formal finance. In KAZA they take two forms. Member-owned groups include village savings and loan associations (VSLAs), rotating savings clubs such as chilimba, motshelo and kixikila, burial societies and lodge-staff savings schemes. Collective funds hold the income communities earn from conservation and tourism, through Namibia's conservancies, Botswana's community trusts, Zambia's Community Resource Boards and Zimbabwe's CAMPFIRE wards. For women and youth living next to protected areas, these mechanisms are often the only finance they use. Zambia alone counts over 800,000 savings-group members, about 73% of them women in one rural sample. Namibia's conservancies earned N$57.7 million from joint-venture tourism in 2023, and women do over 60% of conservancy financial management. These mechanisms build trust, savings discipline and a repayment record. But they lend small sums for short periods and rarely connect to banks. This section maps the main practices and shows where each could be linked to banks, MFIs and guarantees in formal or hybrid models.

Informal finance is widespread across KAZA, mostly run by women, and already disciplined. But it lends only small sums and shares out its capital every year. The table compares six practices by user, mechanism, strength and limit. Each one has a pilot route into formal or hybrid finance. Savings groups and conservancy benefit funds offer the strongest base, because they have records, legal or social structure and recurring income.

Table 8: Informal and community-based finance practices among women and youth

Practice	Where	Who uses it	How it works	Strengths	Limits	Pilot route
VSLAs and savings groups	All five; dense in Zambia (800,000+ members) and Zimbabwe	Women (about 73% in rural Zambia); youth about 28%	Weekly savings, loans at 5–10% a month, annual share-out	Discipline, trust, records kept in passbooks	Loans small (USD 20–500); cash-box risk; share-out drains capital	Linkage banking: group account plus a bulk loan; digitise passbooks
Rotating savings (chilimba ZM, kixikila AO, mukando or round ZW, motshelo BW, okuhanga or oshitopito NA)	All	Women traders, crafters, lodge staff	Fixed rotation of a lump sum	No interest, social collateral	No credit growth; fails when members default	Use rotation records as a credit-history proxy
Burial societies and funeral clubs	All	Older women	Mutual insurance	Large membership, trusted	Not lending vehicles	Micro-insurance distribution channel
Conservancy and trust benefit funds	NA, BW, ZM (CRBs), ZW (CAMPFIRE)	Community members via committees (women about 40% in NA)	Cash dividends, community projects	Recurring income; legal entities	Governance risk; payouts consumed, not invested	Community revolving or guarantee fund with independent management
Lodge staff savings schemes and cooperatives	BW, NA, ZW hubs	Lodge staff, many young	Payroll deduction	Payroll-linked repayment	Tied to employer	Staff-to-entrepreneur loans via payroll-linked SACCOs
Informal moneylenders (kaloba ZM, mashonisa)	All	Youth, emergency borrowers	20–50% a month	Fast	Predatory	Displace with digital nano-loans tied to VSLA data

Recommended hybrid pilots.

1. **VSLA-to-bank graduation.** Run this in Livingstone/Kazungula and Katima Mulilo. Mature groups (2+ cycles) open group accounts. Partner banks or MFIs lend 1–3 times group savings, backed by a facility first-loss. Women's tourism suppliers come first.
2. **Conservancy or CAMPFIRE community guarantee fund.** Pilot this in the Zambezi Region and Hwange/Binga. A community deposits 10–20% of annual JV income into a ring-fenced account at a partner bank. The deposit backs loans to members' tourism enterprises at 3–5 times leverage, and the grant facility matches the deposit.
3. **Digital passbook credit scoring.** Digitise VSLA and kixikila records on mobile money. Lenders then get a repayment history for youth and women with no bank file.

5. Financing requirements by type, size and growth stage

The instrument has to change as firms grow. Start-ups need grants and nano-loans under USD 15,000. Emerging firms need seasonal working capital and asset finance of USD 15,000–75,000. Scaling firms need term debt of USD 75,000–500,000 with guarantees. Ticket sizes are *indicative* ranges from the Financial Landscape Analysis and programme experience.

5.1 By growth stage

Financing needs step up sharply with growth stage, and so does the right instrument. Start-ups need USD 500–15,000, best served by grants and group loans. Emerging firms need USD 15,000–75,000 in a mix of grants, asset finance and guaranteed loans. Scaling firms need USD 75,000–500,000 in term debt. Women- and youth-specific adjustments apply at each stage.

Table 9: Financing requirements by growth stage

Stage	Typical ticket (USD)	Main needs	Best-fit instruments	Women and youth notes
Start-up (under 2 seasons)	500–15,000	Licences, first equipment, mokoro or boat, craft stock, website and booking set-up, training	Seed grant, VSLA loan, MFI group loan, in-kind asset grant	Youth: first-asset grant plus mentoring. Women: grants that accept household-time constraints, childcare-aware training
Emerging (2–5 seasons)	15,000–75,000	Pre-season working capital, vehicle or boat, solar and water, room upgrades, certification	Growth grant plus loan, asset finance or leasing, receivables finance, guaranteed SME loan	Women: alternative collateral, co-signature rules removed. Youth: guarantee uplift
Scaling (5+ seasons)	75,000–500,000	New units or products, fleet expansion, facility upgrade, digital distribution, processing plant	Guaranteed term loan, DFI line, supplier finance, quasi-equity, impact funds	Women-led scale-ups are rare. Target women-owned share via matching leverage

5.2 By MSME type and size

Within each stage, ticket sizes vary widely by segment. Accommodation and transport need the largest amounts, from USD 15,000 to over USD 150,000 for small and medium firms. Crafts and food supply, where women dominate, mostly need under USD 50,000 at micro and small size. This is one reason lenders built for large tickets overlook women-led segments.

Table 10: Ticket sizes by MSME type and size

Type	Micro	Small	Medium
Accommodation	USD 2k–15k: furnishing, solar lights, water tank, listings	USD 15k–150k: room additions, solar, borehole, refurbishment	USD 150k–500k+: new lodge units, JV fit-out
Guiding and activities	USD 1k–10k: mokoro, bikes, licence, first-aid kit	USD 10k–60k: boat and engine, game-drive vehicle (used)	USD 60k–250k: fleet, EV conversion
Transport	USD 5k–20k: motorbike or used minibus deposit	USD 20k–100k: shuttle and 4x4 fleet	USD 100k+: fleet, workshop
Food and agri-supply	USD 500–5k: seed, poultry,	USD 5k–50k: irrigation, cold	USD 50k–200k:

Type	Micro	Small	Medium
	drip kit	room, delivery vehicle	processing, aggregation hub
Crafts and culture	USD 200–3k: materials, stock	USD 3k–25k: workshop, showroom, e-commerce	Rare: cooperative export hub
Support services (laundry, waste, maintenance)	USD 1k–10k: machines, tools	USD 10k–80k: industrial laundry, recycling baler	USD 80k+: service contracts across lodges
Community enterprises	USD 5k–30k: campsite ablutions, signage	USD 30k–200k: community lodge upgrade	USD 200k+: JV equity stakes

5.3 What this means for instruments

- **Grants alone can't scale the sector, and loans alone can't reach start-ups.** The facility needs a graduation path from grant to loan, using the same MSME file, the same TA provider and the same lender.
- **Asset-backed needs are the easiest win.** Vehicles, boats, solar, laundry machines and cold rooms are movable assets. They can be leased or registered as collateral, especially in Zambia and Zimbabwe, where collateral registries operate.
- **Women's needs are smaller, more frequent and working-capital heavy.** Products should allow repeat short-cycle loans and group guarantees rather than a single large term loan.

6. Thematic assessments

6.1 Tourism seasonality, cash flow and debt eligibility (i)

Seasonality is the single largest reason viable tourism MSMEs fail lenders' affordability tests. KAZA's high season runs June–October (dry season, game viewing) with a shoulder in April–May and November. The green season (December–March) brings closures in the Okavango, Kafue and Hwange, as well as flooded roads.

Effect on cash flow (*indicative*). A small lodge, guiding outfit or transfer operator typically earns 60–75% of annual revenue in 5 months. Fixed costs keep running in the low season: staff, lease, vehicle insurance and loan instalments. Suppliers to lodges (food, laundry, crafts) see the same curve one step removed. They also face lodge closures in January–February, when demand falls to near zero.

Effect on eligibility.

- **Affordability tests** use average monthly income against a fixed instalment. Low-season months fail the debt-service ratio, even though the annual cash flow is sound.
- **Arrears in February–March** trigger restructuring, credit-bureau flags and lost eligibility for the next loan. This hits women's micro-enterprises hardest, because they have the thinnest cash buffers.
- **Tenor mismatch.** 12-month MFI loans (e.g. the Women's Microfinance Bank, Zimbabwe) force repayment through a full low season.
- **Currency.** High-end lodges earn USD. Most MSMEs supplying them earn local currency. Kwacha, ZiG and kwanza swings add a second, unpredictable cycle on top of the seasonal one.

Five ways existing debt products can be adapted to seasonality (at least three requested):

All five adaptations keep the lender's annual return the same but shift when repayment falls due. Seasonal schedules and grace periods are the simplest to introduce, because they only change the repayment calendar. Revenue-based and booking-linked finance need digital payment flows or a DMC to confirm bookings, but they tie repayment directly to guest arrivals. A seasonal credit line suits suppliers whose needs peak before the high season.

Table 11: Debt product adaptations for tourism seasonality

Adaptation	How it works	Best for	Lender safeguard
1. Seasonal repayment schedule	Larger instalments June–October, reduced or interest-only December–March. Annual debt service stays the same	Lodges, guides, transfer operators	Cash-flow based underwriting on 12-month projection
2. Seasonal grace period	3–4 month principal holiday aligned to the green season. Capex loans disbursed pre-season start repayment in July	Facility upgrades, vehicles, boats	Grace capitalised; guarantee covers the grace exposure
3. Revenue-based repayment	A fixed share (e.g. 8–15%) of card, mobile-money or OTA receipts is swept to the lender until a capped multiple is repaid	Digitally paid firms: activities, guesthouses, online craft sales	Collection account or payment-processor sweep
4. Forward-booking-linked finance	Pre-season working capital advanced against confirmed bookings or deposits held by DMCs and OTAs, repaid as guests arrive	Lodges, activity operators, DMC-linked suppliers	Assignment of booking proceeds; DMC confirmation
5. Seasonal revolving credit line	Line drawn in the low season for pre-season stock-up and maintenance, cleared by October	Food suppliers, laundries, craft co-ops	Annual clean-up requirement; anchor contract

A *shock clause* adds to all five. It is a pre-agreed 3–6 month moratorium triggered by an objective event: a border closure, drought declaration, pandemic or park closure. This replaces ad-hoc restructuring, which is how COVID-19 and the 2024 drought were handled.

6.2 Land tenure, asset ownership and alternative collateral (ii)

Women- and youth-led MSMEs are excluded from collateral because the land system and inheritance rules route land to men, chiefs or the state. Most KAZA enterprises sit on land of four kinds, and none of it can be mortgaged:

- communal land under traditional authorities (Barotse Royal Establishment, Zambian chiefs, Namibian traditional authorities)
- tribal land under land boards (Botswana)
- RDC-administered communal land (Zimbabwe)
- state-held land (Angola)

On top of that:

- **Women** typically gain land access through husbands or male relatives. In Zimbabwe, women held land in their own name in under 5% of cases before land reform and about 20% after, and communal land is largely unchanged. In Zambia, policy targets moved from 30% (2000) to 50% (2017) allocation to women, but administration lags.
- **Youth** rarely hold land, vehicles or a credit file. Family assets stay in elders' names, and spousal or parental consent rules for pledging assets add a second barrier.
- **Community enterprises** hold leases or JV rights. Their terms (often 10–15 years, with renewal uncertain) are shorter than lenders want for capex loans.

Alternative forms of collateral that lenders could accept:

Nine forms of alternative collateral could stand in for land. They range from vehicles and equipment to receivables, group and community guarantees, and conservation-linked revenues. Group guarantees and anchor-backed receivables are ready now in all five countries and fit women's businesses best. Movable-asset lending is strongest in Zambia and Zimbabwe, where collateral registries operate. Lease rights and conservation assets need more legal work first.

Table 12: Alternative forms of collateral

Collateral type	Example in KAZA	Legal basis	Readiness by country	Women and youth fit
Movable assets: vehicles, boats, engines, equipment	Game-drive vehicles, mokoro fleets, laundry machines, solar systems	Movable property security laws and registries	ZM, ZW operational; BW law passed, commencement pending; NA, AO unclear, to verify	Medium: assets bought with the loan itself (purchase-money security)
Future receivables and contracts	Lodge supply contracts, DMC booking proceeds, Wildlife Credits payments	Assignment of receivables; registry filing where available	High where anchor signs a tripartite agreement (Stanbic BW model)	High: women suppliers hold contracts more often than land
Group guarantees	VSLA or co-op joint liability	Contract law	High everywhere	High: built on women's groups
Community-based guarantees	Conservancy, trust or CAMPFIRE deposit backing members' loans	Trust or association constitution; cash collateral	Medium: needs governance rules	High if allocation rules reserve a share for women and youth
Conservation-linked assets	Wildlife Credits receivables, carbon or biodiversity credit revenues, conservation-performance contracts	Contract; emerging regulation	Low–medium: NA furthest advanced	Medium
Lease and concession rights	Registered leasehold, PTO, JV lease assignment	Land and lease law; landlord consent	Low–medium	Low unless leases are registered in women's names
Cash-flow and digital data	Mobile-money and POS histories as underwriting input	Credit reporting acts	Medium	High for youth
Warehouse receipts and	Craft stock, produce	Warehouse	Low	Medium

Collateral type	Example in KAZA	Legal basis	Readiness by country	Women and youth fit
inventory		receipts and pledge law		
Personal and third-party guarantees from anchors	Lodge operator guarantees a supplier's equipment loan	Contract	Medium	High

Priority actions:

- Require partner lenders to register grant- and loan-financed movable assets in the borrower's name. Register them in the woman's or youth's name where she or he runs the enterprise.
- Remove spousal co-signature requirements for women's business loans where the law doesn't require them.
- Advocate for commencement of Botswana's Movable Property (Security Interests) Act (Botswana Laws).

6.3 Power imbalances between large operators and MSMEs (iii)

A few large lodge groups, DMCs and hotel chains control most guest flows, procurement and pricing. Small suppliers and community partners negotiate from weakness. The anchors include Wilderness, &Beyond, Great Plains, Desert & Delta, Natural Selection, Gondwana, Wild Horizons, Africa Albida, Sun International and Chiawa. This affects working capital, contract quality and, as a result, bankability.

(a) Payment cycles and working capital. Large operators commonly pay suppliers 30–60 days after invoice, and sometimes 90–120 days. Guests, meanwhile, pre-pay lodges 50% about 90 days before arrival (SME South Africa). The supplier thus lends to the buyer, a pattern documented across Southern Africa (Mining Weekly, Oct 2026). For a woman-run vegetable or laundry business turning over USD 2,000 a month, a 60-day cycle locks up about USD 4,000. That is often more than her whole working capital. She can't fill a larger order without credit, and she can't get credit without a track record of larger orders.

(b) Contract terms that disadvantage MSMEs (*indicative*, from operator and CBNRM literature; to verify in interviews):

- **No written contract at all.** Purchase orders are issued week to week, so there is nothing to assign to a lender.
- **Unilateral cancellation and volume changes.** Orders are cut in the low season, or during COVID-style shocks, with no notice.
- **Quality rejection without appeal.** The supplier bears the full loss.
- **Exclusivity clauses** for activity operators and guides, with commission rates set by the operator (often 20–30% for DMCs and OTAs).
- **JV and lease agreements.** Community partners often receive fixed fees or a revenue share calculated on operator-reported figures, with weak audit rights. Long tenures carry few performance-review clauses, and assets revert to the operator rather than the community.
- **Payment currency mismatch.** Operators earn USD but pay suppliers in local currency at their own conversion rate.

(c) Supply chain finance that could rebalance power:

Five supply chain finance tools would let MSME suppliers borrow on the strength of large operators' credit rather than their own. Reverse factoring and contract-backed loans move the most risk to the anchor. The Wilderness–Stanbic arrangement in Botswana proves the contract-backed model already works in KAZA. Purchase-order finance, sponsored leasing and dynamic discounting fill specific gaps.

Table 13: Supply chain finance instruments

Instrument	Mechanism	Precedent
Reverse factoring	The bank pays the MSME's approved invoice in 2–5 days at a discount priced on the *anchor's* credit risk. The anchor pays the bank at 60 days	Common in corporate banking; adapt via Stanbic, FNB, Absa
Contract-backed supplier loans	A tripartite agreement in which the operator nominates the supplier, the bank lends against the contract, and the operator pays into a collection account	Wilderness–Stanbic Botswana, 2025 (Daily News)
Purchase-order finance	Advance of 50–70% of a confirmed order for inputs	Food and craft suppliers
Anchor-sponsored equipment leasing	The operator guarantees or co-signs leases for laundry, solar or cold-chain equipment used to serve it	Supplier-development programmes
Dynamic discounting	The operator pays early from its own cash in exchange for a small discount	Requires operator treasury willingness

The grant facility can fund three things here: the platform and onboarding costs, a first-loss on the MSME pool, and TA to help suppliers meet quality standards.

(d) Dialogue platforms to address these imbalances:

1. **KAZA Tourism Supply Chain Compact.** Operators sign voluntary pledges: payment within 15 days for micro suppliers, written contracts, a local-procurement share, and women and youth supplier targets. A dashboard reports progress yearly to the KAZA Secretariat.
2. **National hub roundtables**, quarterly, in Kasane/Maun, Katima Mulilo/Rundu, Livingstone and Victoria Falls. These are chaired by tourism boards (BTO, NTB, ZTA (Zambia), ZTA (Zimbabwe)) and LEA, CEEC or SMEDCO, with operator associations, MSME associations, women's and youth groups, and banks.
3. **Model contract working group.** HATAB, FENATA, TCZ, TBCSA-type bodies, CBNRM associations (NACSO, BOCOBONET) and lawyers develop standard supply contracts and JV clauses: audit rights, performance review, women's and youth employment.
4. **Grievance and mediation channel** for suppliers and community partners, hosted by a neutral body such as a chamber of commerce or the CBNRM association.

5. **Annual KAZA R-NBT Finance Forum** where operators, lenders and MSMEs review supply-chain finance performance.

6.4 Root causes (iv)

The visible barriers (no collateral, high rates, rejection) trace back to three root causes. Each one reinforces the other two.

Three root causes sit behind most of the barriers. They are information gaps, the high cost of serving small borrowers far from decision centres, and collateral rules. Each falls harder on women and youth. Each has a fix that tackles the cause rather than the symptom.

Table 14: Root causes of the finance gap

Root cause	How it shows up	Gendered and youth effect	Fix that addresses the cause
Information asymmetries	MSMEs lack records, audited accounts and credit files. Lenders lack sector data on seasonality, default rates and R-NBT business models. MSMEs don't know what products exist	Women's businesses are mixed with household cash; youth have no credit file. Fewer women hear of products (about 60% of women consulted in Zimbabwe didn't know the Women's Microfinance Bank)	Digital bookkeeping and payment trails, shared KAZA sector data, product fairs through VSLAs and conservancies
High transaction costs	Distances of 300–1,000 km to credit decision centres (Windhoek, Gaborone, Lusaka, Harare, Luanda). Small tickets make fixed appraisal costs prohibitive	Women face time and mobility constraints. Youth applications are small and numerous	Portfolio approaches, digital origination, BSO pre-screening, field agents in hubs
Collateral requirements	Banks ask for 100–150% of the loan in immovable collateral	Women and youth rarely hold titled land or vehicles	Guarantees, movable and receivables collateral, cash-flow lending (6.2)

Underneath all three sits *perceived* rather than *measured* risk. Lenders have almost no repayment data on tourism MSMEs in KAZA, so they price for the worst case. The facility should therefore publish anonymised portfolio performance by gender, age, segment and season.

6.5 How financial institutions view risk across MSME categories (v)

Section 3.1 rates perceived risk by category. Three patterns matter for design:

- **Risk ranking follows assets, not viability.** Asset-heavy, male-dominated transport is rated lower risk than women's food supply, even though food supply may have steadier cash flow.
- **Community ownership is penalised for governance, not for business risk.** Lenders cite elite capture, disputes and committee turnover.
- **Youth risk is about the absence of history.** A guarantee plus 2–3 seasons of repayment data could move youth-led firms into standard credit.

6.6 Lender expectations, gaps and regenerative NBT knowledge (vi)

Lenders ask for seven things that most KAZA tourism MSMEs can't yet supply. The widest gaps are collateral, financial records and business plans, and the own contribution start-ups are expected to put in. Each gap has a practical bridge the facility can fund or broker, such as accepting mobile-money statements or a one-page seasonal plan.

Table 15: Lender expectations, MSME realities and bridges

Lender expectation	Typical MSME reality	Gap	Bridge
12–36 months of financial records, bank statements	Cash, mobile money, exercise-book records	Large	Simple digital bookkeeping app, 6 months of mobile-money statements accepted
Business plan with cash-flow projections	No plan, or plans written for grant applications	Large	Standard one-page plan plus a 12-month seasonal cash-flow template
Registration, tax clearance, tourism licence	Many operate unlicensed or with expired licences	Medium	Licensing support funded as an eligible grant cost
Collateral of 100–150%	Communal land	Very large	See 6.2
Own contribution of 20–30%	Little cash equity	Large for start-ups	Counted in kind; grants as quasi-equity
Market evidence (contracts, bookings)	Verbal agreements with lodges	Medium	Written contracts via the Supply Chain Compact
E&S compliance	Not documented	Medium	Simple R-NBT checklist (below)

Knowledge gaps on regenerative NBT principles:

- **MSMEs** often don't know how to show regenerative practice in terms lenders value. Examples are lower energy and water costs from solar and boreholes, premium pricing from certification (Fair Trade Tourism, Eco Awards Namibia, Botswana Ecotourism Certification), access to Wildlife Credits and conservation-linked revenues, or operator preference for verified local suppliers.
- **Lenders** rarely understand regenerative criteria. They see conservation features as cost rather than resilience. They don't price the lower climate and shock risk of diversified, community-anchored businesses, and they lack a taxonomy to tag loans as green or nature-positive for their own ESG and DFI reporting.
- **Shared gap:** no common, simple R-NBT definition. The facility should adopt a 10-point *KAZA R-NBT checklist* covering energy, water, waste, biodiversity contribution, community benefit, women's and youth employment, local procurement, cultural integrity, wildlife-conflict mitigation and climate resilience. It should be usable by MSMEs for self-assessment and by lenders for tagging.

6.7 Trust-building dialogue topics (vii)

These topics are for MSME–lender–operator dialogues, ranked by expected effect on trust:

1. **What lenders actually need.** A walk-through of credit assessment, why loans are rejected, and what an acceptable record looks like. Run it in local languages through VSLAs and conservancies.
2. **Seasonality in practice.** MSMEs show real cash-flow calendars, and lenders present seasonal products. Together they co-design repayment schedules.

3. **Collateral alternatives.** How registries work and what movable assets and contracts can secure, with a myth-busting session on land.
4. **Payment terms and contracts.** Operators and suppliers negotiate the Compact's terms.
5. **Pricing transparency.** The effective interest rate, fees and the real cost of moneylenders compared with formal credit.
6. **Default and shock handling.** What happens in a drought or a closure, and pre-agreed shock clauses.
7. **Women- and youth-specific barriers.** Spousal consent, mobility, childcare and harassment risks. These are run as safe, women-only and youth-only sessions.
8. **Regenerative value.** How conservation and community features reduce risk, and how lenders can tag and report them.
9. **Data sharing and consent.** How mobile-money and VSLA data can be used for credit without loss of privacy.
10. **Community governance.** How trusts and conservancies can make their funds credible to banks.

6.8 Barriers and opportunities for connecting MSMEs and capital providers (viii)

Eight barriers keep MSMEs and capital providers apart, and each has a matching opportunity. The biggest are credit decisions made in distant capitals, the lack of an investment-ready pipeline, and grant programmes that stop short of a loan. Most of the opportunities are coordination fixes the facility can provide directly.

Table 16: Barriers and opportunities for connecting MSMEs and capital providers

Barrier	Opportunity
Credit decisions sit in capitals; hub branches have low approval limits	Delegated authority for guaranteed tourism portfolios; mobile loan officers on hub rotations
No investment-ready pipeline; BSOs and NGOs work in silos	One KAZA MSME pipeline with a shared diagnostic, run by BSOs (LEA, NTB/SME units, CEEC, SMEDCO, INAPEM) and NGOs
Grant programmes don't hand MSMEs on to lenders	Grant-to-loan graduation built into the facility (Window C requires a lender)
MSMEs distrust banks after rejections and high fees	Trust-building dialogues (6.7); lender clinics at VSLA and conservancy meetings
Language barriers: Portuguese in Angola; Silozi, Setswana, Ndebele, Tonga and others	Materials translated, local facilitators
Cross-border firms (Kazungula, Victoria Falls–Livingstone, Ngoma) can't use one lender	Aligned guarantee terms across CGS, ZCGS and ECGC; regional counter-guarantee
Digital exclusion of older women; data costs for youth	Agent-assisted digital onboarding; zero-rated booking and finance apps
USAID withdrawal in 2025 removed key TA providers	EU–German R-NBT action and foundations fill the TA gap; co-funding with the World Bank Zambia tourism project

The project could act as a **matchmaking function** with four parts: a pipeline platform, quarterly deal days in each hub, a lender-of-record roster in each country, and a dashboard tracking applications, approvals and rejection reasons by gender and age.

6.9 Preferences: seed funding vs growth grants (ix)

Preferences vary by stage and by who leads the firm. These are *indicative*, from programme experience, and to be tested in the baseline survey.

Preference between seed and growth funding depends on stage and on who leads the firm. Youth-led start-ups and women-led micro firms are likely to prefer seed grants and in-kind assets, given limited capital and wariness of debt. Emerging and scaling firms gain more from growth or leverage grants that unlock loans. Each preference maps to a facility window.

Table 17: Funding preferences by applicant group

Group	Likely preference	Why	Design implication
Youth-led start-ups	Seed grants (in-kind assets plus mentoring)	No capital or credit history; need first asset and market entry	Window A, quick decisions, cohort mentoring
Women-led micro enterprises	Small seed or growth grants, paid in tranches, combined with VSLA or group credit	Debt aversion after past over-indebtedness; working-capital needs	Windows A and B; tranches tied to milestones; no land collateral
Community enterprises	Growth grants for facilities, matched by community funds	Collective assets, governance processes	Window B with governance conditions
Emerging formal MSMEs	Growth grants that unlock loans	Have some capacity to borrow; grant lowers risk	Window B or C
Scaling MSMEs	Leverage grants or first-loss rather than outright grants	Capital needs exceed grant sizes	Window C, with a lender term sheet required

The split should be about **35% seed and 65% growth or scale by value**, but 60% seed by number of grants. This lets the facility reach many women and youth while placing most money where it leverages debt.

6.10 Realistic matching contribution capacity (x)

A flat 20% or 50% match would select for already-advantaged applicants. Matching should rise with stage and be adjusted for women, youth and community applicants.

Realistic matching capacity ranges from close to nothing for youth start-ups to 30–50% for scaling firms. A flat 20% or 50% requirement would therefore exclude most women and youth applicants. The recommended rates follow capacity: 10% for youth and women-led micro firms, 20% for community enterprises, 25–30% for emerging firms and 50% for scaling firms. In-kind contributions are allowed on a sliding scale.

Table 18: Recommended matching contributions by applicant type

Applicant	Realistic cash capacity	Recommended match	Of which in kind allowed	Comment
Youth-led start-up	0–5%	**10%**	Up to 100%	Labour, materials, VSLA

Applicant	Realistic cash capacity	Recommended match	Of which in kind allowed	Comment
				savings count
Women-led micro, start-up or emerging	5–15%	**10–15%**	Up to 75%	VSLA savings and group contributions count
Community enterprise	10–20% (from JV or CAMPFIRE income)	**20%**	Up to 50%	Community fund deposit counts
Emerging MSME (any)	15–25%	**25–30%**	Up to 50%	20% feasible; above 30% excludes
Scaling MSME	30–50% (incl. loans)	**50%**	Up to 20%	At least half of the match from a loan

The recommended adjustments are:

- Cut the standard 20% to 10% for youth and for women-led micro firms.
- Keep 20% for community enterprises, but count the community guarantee-fund deposit as match.
- Reserve 50% for scaling firms, with loans counting as match.
- Allow the match to be paid in tranches over the grant period, not upfront.

6.11 Funding needs by type (xi)

The categories follow the request. Priority and gender-age fit are *indicative*.

The seven funding categories differ in ticket size and in how well they fit women and youth. Digital platforms, equipment and marketing are low-cost, high-fit categories that seed grants can cover. Facility upgrades and circular-economy capex at scale are larger and suit blended grant-and-loan finance. Conservation investments are best paired with results-based payments such as Wildlife Credits.

Table 19: Funding needs by category

Category	Examples	Typical ticket (USD)	Main users	Fit with women and youth	Best instrument
Equipment	Mokoros, boats, bikes, laundry machines, kitchen, craft tools	500–60,000	Guides, suppliers, crafters	High	Seed grant (small), leasing or asset finance (large)
Facility upgrades	Rooms, ablutions, campsites, workshops, showrooms	5,000–150,000	Accommodation, community enterprises	Medium	Growth grant plus guaranteed loan
Digital platforms	Websites, OTA listings, booking engines, POS, mobile money, bookkeeping apps	300–5,000	All, especially youth	Very high	Seed grant (in kind), bundled
New products	Cultural tours, birding, river trips, food experiences, women-guided walks	2,000–30,000	Activities, community enterprises	High	Seed or growth grant
Conservation	HWC mitigation, restoration, monitoring, anti-poaching support,	2,000–50,000	Community enterprises, conservancies	Medium	Grant; results-based payments (Wildlife Credits)

Category	Examples	Typical ticket (USD)	Main users	Fit with women and youth	Best instrument
	wildlife-friendly fencing				
Circular economy	Recycling, composting, upcycled crafts, greywater, solar and energy efficiency	1,000–80,000	Youth enterprises, lodges' suppliers	High for youth	Grant (start-up), green asset finance (scale)
Marketing	Branding, trade fairs (e.g. Our Heritage, Sanganai), photography, certification fees	500–10,000	All	High	Seed grant; co-marketing with anchors

7. Recommendations

Each actor has a distinct part to play. The facility in Section 8 is the instrument that ties them together.

Financial institutions (banks, MFIs, development financiers)

1. Launch seasonal tourism products with the five adaptations in 6.1, starting with seasonal schedules and green-season grace.
2. Accept movable assets, receivables, group guarantees and community deposits as collateral. Register assets in the name of the woman or youth who runs the business.
3. Drop spousal or parental co-signature requirements not required by law. Accept 6 months of mobile-money statements in place of bank statements.
4. Delegate approval authority for guaranteed portfolios to hub branches in Kasane, Maun, Katima Mulilo, Livingstone and Victoria Falls.
5. Report tourism MSME lending by sex and age of owner and by season. Share anonymised data with the facility.

Credit guarantee schemes and DFIs (CGS, ZCGS, ECGC, FGC, AGF, AFAWA, KfW, EIB, IFC, AfDB)

1. Open KAZA tourism windows with a cover uplift for women and youth: 70% compared with 50–60% standard.
2. Provide counter-guarantees and wholesale lines in local currency.
3. Support design of a Botswana guarantee facility, which could be hosted by CEDA, NDB or BDC with AGF.

Governments and the KAZA Secretariat

1. Commence and operationalise movable collateral registries, Botswana first. Verify Namibia's and Angola's frameworks.
2. Simplify tourism licensing for micro operators: tiered licences, one-stop windows in hubs, and licence fees counted as grant-eligible costs.
3. Adopt the KAZA R-NBT checklist as a common eligibility and tagging standard.
4. Host the Supply Chain Compact and the annual R-NBT Finance Forum.
5. Enforce women's land and lease registration targets, and support joint titling and registered leases for women on communal land.

Large tourism operators and DMCs

1. Sign the Supply Chain Compact. It commits operators to written contracts, payment within 15 days to micro suppliers, and local, women and youth procurement targets.

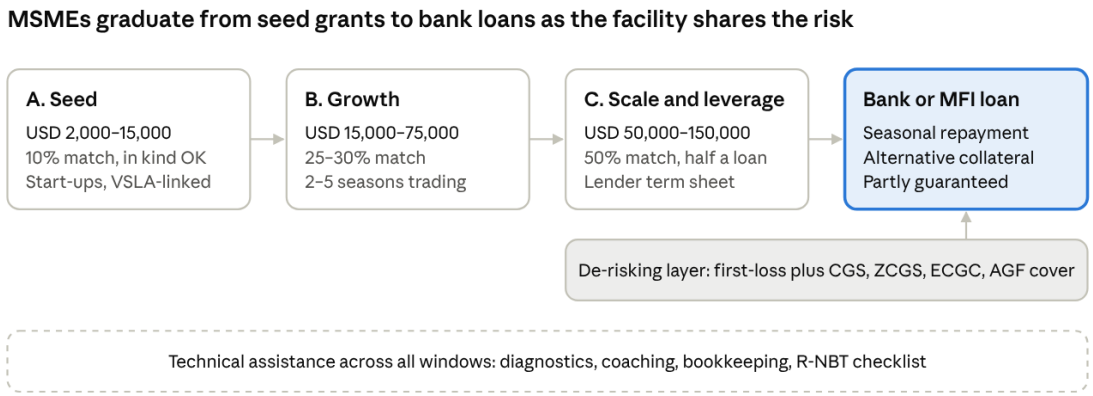
2. Join tripartite supply-chain finance (Wilderness–Stanbic model) and sponsor equipment leases for suppliers.
3. Add audit rights and women's and youth employment clauses to JV agreements at renewal.

MSME associations, BSOs, CBNRM bodies and NGOs

1. Run the shared pipeline diagnostic and investment-readiness coaching.
2. Facilitate VSLA-to-bank graduation and community guarantee funds.
3. Convene women-only and youth-only sessions within dialogue platforms.

8. Grant facility design: KAZA R-NBT Enterprise Facility

The facility is a three-window, performance-based grant fund. It graduates MSMEs from seed grants to bank loans and uses a de-risking layer to bring lenders in. It reserves at least half of grant value for women-led and 40% for youth-led enterprises.



KAZA R-NBT Enterprise Facility · 3 grant windows, de-risking layer, TA

Each window feeds the next. Window C and the de-risking layer exist to hand the MSME on to a partner lender.

8.1 Objectives

1. Help women-, youth- and community-led tourism MSMEs near protected areas start, upgrade and grow regenerative businesses.
2. Unlock commercial and development finance for these MSMEs at a target leverage of at least 1:1 by facility close.
3. Build a disaggregated evidence base on tourism MSME finance in KAZA.

8.2 Structure and allocation

The R-NBT action budget is not public, so shares are shown as percentages of the facility envelope.

Seventy percent of the facility goes to grants, split 35:40:25 across the seed, growth and scale windows. A further 15% funds the de-risking layer that brings lenders in. Technical assistance takes 10%, and measurement and administration take 5%.

Table 20: Facility structure and allocation

Component	Share of envelope	Purpose
Window A: Seed	24.5% (35% of grant pool)	Start-ups, VSLA-linked and community micro enterprises
Window B: Growth	28% (40% of grant pool)	Emerging MSMEs: upgrades, equipment, products
Window C: Scale and leverage	17.5% (25% of grant pool)	Scaling MSMEs with a lender term sheet; grant as quasi-equity or first-loss on their own loan
De-risking layer	15%	First-loss on partner-lender tourism portfolios; per-loan origination incentives for performing women- and youth-led loans; community guarantee fund matching
Technical assistance and pipeline	10%	Diagnostics, coaching, bookkeeping and digital onboarding, R-NBT checklist, lender training, dialogues
MEL and administration	5%	Data system, disaggregated reporting, evaluations

8.3 Window terms

The window terms set out how size, stage, matching, disbursement, formality and lender links tighten from seed to scale. Seed grants ask the least: a 10% match, payment largely in kind, and six months to register. Scale grants require a lender's term sheet and two years of accounts.

Table 21: Grant window terms

Term	A. Seed	B. Growth	C. Scale and leverage
Grant size (USD)	2,000–15,000	15,000–75,000	50,000–150,000
Stage	Start-up (under 2 seasons)	Emerging (2–5 seasons)	Scaling (5+ seasons)
Matching	10% (youth, women micro); 20% for community enterprises	25–30%	50%, at least half a loan
In-kind match allowed	Up to 100%	Up to 50%	Up to 20%
Disbursement	In-kind assets plus 2 cash tranches	3 milestone tranches	Tied to loan disbursement
Formality required	Basic registration within 6 months (cost covered)	Registered, licensed	Registered, licensed, 2 years of accounts
Lender link	Group or VSLA account opened	Loan referral encouraged	Lender term sheet mandatory
Eligible uses	Equipment, digital,	All categories in 6.11	Facility upgrades, fleets,

Term	A. Seed	B. Growth	C. Scale and leverage
	marketing, new products, licences		circular and conservation capex

8.4 Eligibility and targeting

- **Location:** enterprise operates in the KAZA TFCA. Priority goes to wards, conservancies, trusts and GMAs next to protected areas: 60% of grant value or more.
- **Women-led:** 51% or more owned by women, or 25% or more owned by women with a woman CEO or managing partner (2X Challenge-aligned). Target: at least 50% of grant value.
- **Youth-led:** 51% or more owned by people aged 18–35. Target: at least 40% of grant value (overlap with women-led allowed).
- **Community enterprises:** legally constituted trust, conservancy, CRB or CAMPFIRE ward enterprise, with a benefit-sharing plan showing allocation to women and youth.
- **Regenerative screen:** a minimum score on the 10-point KAZA R-NBT checklist (6.6), with an improvement plan.
- **Exclusions:** hunting operations (unless the facility's donors decide otherwise), firms already above USD 2 million turnover, and enterprises on the IFC exclusion list.

8.5 Selection criteria and weights

Applicants are scored on six weighted criteria. Business viability carries the most weight at 25%. Regenerative contribution and inclusion of women, youth and communities count 20% each, so a firm can't win on financials alone. Market links, leverage and closeness to a protected area make up the remaining 35%.

Table 22: Selection criteria and weights

Criterion	Weight
Business viability and seasonal cash-flow plan	25%
Regenerative contribution (R-NBT checklist)	20%
Women, youth and community inclusion (ownership, jobs, benefit-sharing)	20%
Market linkage (contracts, bookings, anchor letter)	15%
Leverage potential (loan or own funds)	10%
Proximity to protected area and conservation link	10%

Women and youth applicants are scored by panels that include women and youth members. Pitch-based selection is done in local languages.

8.6 Governance and delivery

- **Facility manager:** a competitively selected fund manager or consortium with a KAZA presence and a hub office in Kasane.
- **Investment committee:** KAZA Secretariat, GIZ, an EU observer, two independent finance experts, and one women's and one youth representative. Each Partner State is represented on a rotating basis.

- **Country delivery partners:** LEA and CEDA (BW), NTB/MIT SME units and DBN (NA), CEEC and ZDA (ZM), SMEDCO and ZTA (ZW), INAPEM (AO). NGOs such as WWF, Peace Parks, CI, AWF and NACSO help with outreach and coaching.
- **Partner lenders:** at least one bank or MFI per country under a cooperation agreement covering seasonal products, alternative collateral, data sharing and the first-loss terms.
- **Process:** a call per country per year, then pre-screen, diagnostic, 6–8 weeks of coaching, pitch, IC decision, tranche contracts and graduation tracking. Target decision time is 60 days or less.

8.7 Measurement, evaluation and learning

All indicators are disaggregated by sex and age of owner (under 25, 25–35, over 35), enterprise size, stage, segment, country and protected-area adjacency.

The indicators track reach, leverage, graduation to loans, loan quality by season, jobs, payment terms and regenerative performance. Every indicator is broken down by sex and age of owner. Lender rejection reasons are also recorded, to build the evidence base this report found missing.

Table 23: Measurement indicators and indicative targets

Indicator	Target (indicative)
MSMEs supported (grants)	Set by budget; at least 50% women-led, at least 40% youth-led
Finance leveraged (loans plus own funds) per grant dollar	1:1 or better at close; 2:1 for Window C
Grantees who access a formal loan within 24 months	30% or more
Portfolio at risk over 30 days on facility-linked loans, by season	8% or less in high season, 15% or less in low season
Jobs created or sustained (FTE), women and youth share	Women 50% or more, youth 40% or more
Average days to supplier payment (Compact signatories)	15 days or less for micro suppliers
R-NBT checklist score improvement	+2 points on average
Rejection reasons recorded by lenders (by gender and age)	100% of referrals

Primary data to collect at inception:

- An MSME baseline survey of about 600 MSMEs across 5 countries, stratified by sex, age, segment and adjacency, covering cash-flow seasonality, collateral holdings and informal finance use.
- Interviews with 25–30 financial institutions on risk views, products and willingness to adopt women and youth incentives.
- Operator surveys on payment days and contract terms.
- VSLA and conservancy fund mapping in the pilot hubs.

8.8 Key risks and mitigations

Six main risks could undermine the facility: elite capture, grant dependency, low lender uptake, shocks, gender backlash and environmental harm. Each has a specific mitigation built into the design. Low lender uptake draws directly on the lesson of Zimbabwe's Tourism Revival Fund.

Table 24: Key facility risks and mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Elite capture of community grants	Benefit-sharing plans, women and youth quotas, public disclosure, independent audit
Grant dependency, no graduation to finance	Mandatory lender link in Window C; graduation milestones; first-loss tied to lending
Low lender uptake (as with Zimbabwe's USD 15m Tourism Revival Fund)	Bank-intermediated delivery, local-currency and USD options, simple process, active BSO marketing
Shocks (drought, pandemic, currency)	Shock clauses, contingency reserve (5% of the de-risking layer)
Gender-based backlash or control of women's grants by others	Women-only sessions, assets registered in women's names, safeguarding and GBV referral
Wildlife and environmental harm	R-NBT screening, E&S exclusion list, monitoring

Annex A. Stakeholder contact database

The database lists 69 institutions across the region and the five Partner States, with each one's role in the facility. Named people, phone numbers and emails are deliberately left out. They should be confirmed from official sources when interviews are scheduled, and they are subject to data-protection consent. Websites are the institutions' known official domains and still need checking. *To confirm* marks a domain that wasn't established. A CSV copy, with space for named contacts, is in the project repository (`annex/KAZA_Stakeholder_Contact_Database.csv`).

The 69 institutions break down as 13 regional organisations, 13 in Botswana, 11 in Namibia, 12 in Zambia, 12 in Zimbabwe and 8 in Angola. They cover lenders, guarantee schemes, development partners, business support organisations, tourism boards, operators and CBNRM bodies. Within each country, finance and delivery partners are listed first.

Table 25: Stakeholder contact database

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
R01	KAZA TFCA Secretariat	Regional	Government / TFCA	Facility host; IC member; Supply Chain Compact convenor	Kasane (BW)	Executive Director; Tourism and Enterprise Programme Officer	kavangozambezi.org
R02	GIZ (R-NBT Joint Action in KAZA)	Regional	Development partner	Implementer; IC member; TA lead	Gaborone / Kasane (BW)	R-NBT Project Lead	giz.de
R03	Delegation of the European Union to Botswana and SADC	Regional	Development partner	Co-funder; IC observer	Gaborone (BW)	Programme Manager Green Economy / Tourism	eeas.europa.eu
R04	KfW Development Bank	Regional	DFI	KAZA financial cooperation; co-financing of de-risking layer	Frankfurt / regional office	Portfolio Manager Biodiversity / SADC TFCAs	kfw.de
R05	African Guarantee Fund (AGF)	Regional	Guarantee	Counter-guarantee for national tourism windows; women's guarantees	Regional (Nairobi HQ; Southern Africa coverage)	Head of Partnerships Southern Africa	africanguaranteefund.com
R06	African Development Bank – AFAWA	Regional	DFI	Women's risk-sharing (up to 75%); TA to lenders	Regional (Abidjan HQ; Southern Africa hub Pretoria)	AFAWA Programme Coordinator	afdb.org
R07	International Finance Corporation (IFC)	Regional	DFI	Risk-sharing facilities; collateral registry TA (BW)	Johannesburg / Lusaka	SME Banking and Gender Lead Southern Africa	ifc.org
R08	World Bank	Regional	DFI	Zambia GREAT tourism project (matching grants); Findex/Enterprise Survey data	Lusaka / Washington	Task Team Leader P180337	worldbank.org

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
R09	Peace Parks Foundation	Regional	NGO	Community enterprise outreach (Simalaha and others)	Stellenbosch / KAZA field offices	KAZA Programme Manager	peaceparks.org
R10	WWF (Namibia / Zambia / Zimbabwe / KAZA)	Regional	NGO	Wildlife Credits; CBNRM enterprise support	Windhoek / Lusaka / Harare	KAZA Landscape Lead	wwf.panda.org
R11	African Wildlife Foundation (AWF)	Regional	NGO	Community conservation enterprises (Kazungula landscape)	Nairobi / Zimbabwe field office	Conservation Enterprise Lead	awf.org
R12	Conservation International	Regional	NGO	KAZA conservation finance	Botswana / Zambia	Southern Africa Programme Director	conservation.org
R13	Adventure Travel Trade Association (ATTA)	Regional	Industry association	Market access; regenerative tourism standards	Global	Africa Regional Director	atta.travel
B01	Citizen Entrepreneurial Development Agency (CEDA)	Botswana	DFI / empowerment	Tourism window; co-financing Window C; candidate guarantee host	Maun / Kasane branches	Head of Tourism Lending; Branch Managers	ceda.co.bw
B02	Local Enterprise Authority (LEA)	Botswana	BSO	Delivery partner: pipeline; coaching; Wilderness supplier MoU	Maun / Kasane	Chief Executive Officer; Regional Manager North	lea.co.bw
B03	National Development Bank (NDB)	Botswana	DFI	SME lending; candidate guarantee host	Maun	Head of SME	ndb.bw
B04	Stanbic Bank Botswana	Botswana	Commercial bank	Supplier finance (Wilderness model); partner lender	Maun / Kasane / Gaborone	Head of Business and Commercial Banking	stanbicbank.co.bw
B05	Absa Bank Botswana	Botswana	Commercial bank	Partner lender; women's banking	Maun / Kasane	Head of SME / Women in Business	absa.co.bw
B06	First National Bank Botswana	Botswana	Commercial bank	Partner lender	Maun / Kasane	Head of Small Business	fnbbotswana.co.bw
B07	Letshego Botswana	Botswana	MFI	Micro and payroll-linked lending	Maun	Head of MSE Lending	letshego.com
B08	Botswana Tourism Organisation (BTO)	Botswana	Tourism board	Hub roundtable chair; grading and certification	Maun / Kasane	Product Development and Ecotourism Certification Manager	botswanatourism.co.bw
B09	Hospitality and Tourism Association of Botswana (HATAB)	Botswana	Industry association	Operator mobilisation; Supply Chain Compact	Maun	Chief Executive Officer	hatab.bw

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
B10	Wilderness	Botswana	Large operator	Anchor; supplier finance pilot; Compact signatory	Maun	Head of Sustainability / Procurement	wildernessdestinations.com
B11	Botswana Community Based Organisations Network (BOCOBONET)	Botswana	CBNRM	Community trusts outreach; community guarantee fund	Maun	Coordinator	to confirm
B12	Ministry of Youth / Youth Development Fund	Botswana	Government	Youth window co-financing	Gaborone / district offices	Youth Development Fund Coordinator	gov.bw
B13	Bank of Botswana / Ministry of Finance (Collateral Registry)	Botswana	Regulator	Movable collateral registry commencement	Gaborone	Financial Inclusion / Collateral Registry Lead	bankofbotswana.bw
N01	Development Bank of Namibia (DBN)	Namibia	DFI	Tourism window; CGS administrator; partner lender	Katima Mulilo / Rundu / Windhoek	Head of SME Finance; CGS Manager	dbn.com.na
N02	Environmental Investment Fund of Namibia (EIF)	Namibia	Green fund	Green asset finance; conservancy grants	Windhoek	Head of Programmes / Green Finance	eif.org.na
N03	Namibian Association of CBNRM Support Organisations (NACSO)	Namibia	CBNRM	Conservancy outreach; model JV clauses; data	Windhoek / Katima Mulilo	Director	nacso.org.na
N04	Community Conservation Fund of Namibia (CCFN)	Namibia	Community fund	Wildlife Credits; community guarantee fund management	Windhoek	Executive Director	ccfn.org.na
N05	Ministry of Environment Forestry and Tourism (MEFT)	Namibia	Government	Concessions; conservancy policy; KAZA NCU	Windhoek / Katima Mulilo	KAZA National Coordinator	meft.gov.na
N06	Namibia Tourism Board (NTB)	Namibia	Tourism board	Licensing simplification; hub roundtable	Windhoek / Katima Mulilo	Industry Services Manager	namibiatourism.com.na
N07	Federation of Namibian Tourism Associations (FENATA)	Namibia	Industry association	Operator mobilisation; Compact	Windhoek	Chief Executive Officer	to confirm
N08	Bank Windhoek	Namibia	Commercial bank	Partner lender (CGS participant)	Katima Mulilo / Rundu	Head of SME Banking	bankwindhoek.com.na
N09	First National Bank Namibia	Namibia	Commercial bank	Partner lender (CGS participant)	Katima Mulilo / Rundu	Head of Small Business	fnbnamibia.com.na
N10	Namibia Special Risks Insurance Association (NASRIA)	Namibia	Guarantee / insurer	CGS risk partner	Windhoek	Credit Guarantee Manager	nasria.com.na
N11	Gondwana Collection	Namibia	Large operator	Anchor; local procurement	Windhoek / Zambezi lodges	Sustainability Manager	gondwana-collection.com

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
Z01	Citizens Economic Empowerment Commission (CEEC)	Zambia	DFI / empowerment	Co-financing; vehicle loans; delivery partner	Livingstone / Mongu	Director General; Provincial Officers	ceec.org.zm
Z02	Zambia Credit Guarantee Scheme (ZCGS)	Zambia	Guarantee	Tourism window with women and youth uplift	Lusaka	Chief Executive Officer	to confirm
Z03	Bank of Zambia (SBGI pilot guarantee; NFIS II)	Zambia	Regulator	Policy; guarantee pilot; disaggregated reporting	Lusaka / Livingstone office	Director Financial Inclusion	boz.zm
Z04	FNB Zambia	Zambia	Commercial bank	Partner lender (ZCGS K100m partnership; women and youth focus)	Livingstone	Head of Business Banking	fnbzambia.co.zm
Z05	Absa Bank Zambia	Zambia	Commercial bank	Partner lender (CEEC facility)	Livingstone	Head of SME	absa.co.zm
Z06	Stanbic Bank Zambia	Zambia	Commercial bank	Supplier finance replication	Livingstone	Head of Business Banking	stanbicbank.co.zm
Z07	FINCA Zambia	Zambia	MFI	Micro lending; women and youth (prior UNCDF guarantee)	Livingstone	Chief Executive Officer	finca.org
Z08	Ministry of Tourism / GREAT project PIU	Zambia	Government	Matching grants co-ordination; KAZA NCU	Lusaka / Livingstone	Project Coordinator; KAZA National Coordinator	mot.gov.zm
Z09	Zambia Tourism Agency	Zambia	Tourism board	Hub roundtable; licensing	Livingstone	Director Product Development	zambia.travel
Z10	Zambia Development Agency (ZDA)	Zambia	BSO	MSME development; pipeline	Lusaka / Livingstone	Director MSME Development	zda.org.zm
Z11	Tourism Council of Zambia / Livingstone Tourism Association	Zambia	Industry association	Operator mobilisation; Compact	Livingstone	Chair	to confirm
Z12	Simalaha Community Conservancy (with Peace Parks)	Zambia	Community	Community enterprise pilot	Kazungula / Sesheke	Conservancy Manager	peaceparks.org
W01	Small and Medium Enterprises Development Corporation (SMEDCO)	Zimbabwe	DFI / BSO	Delivery partner; on-lending	Victoria Falls / Hwange / Bulawayo	Provincial Manager Matabeleland North	smedco.co.zw
W02	Export Credit Guarantee Corporation (ECGC) – MSME	Zimbabwe	Guarantee	Tourism window; USD guarantees	Harare / Bulawayo	Managing Director	ecgc.co.zw

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
	Credit Guarantee Scheme						
W03	Zimbabwe Women's Microfinance Bank	Zimbabwe	MFI / women's bank	Women's lending; seasonal product pilot	Victoria Falls / Bulawayo	Chief Executive Officer	womensbank.co.zw
W04	CBZ Bank	Zimbabwe	Commercial bank	Partner lender	Victoria Falls	Head of SME Banking	cbz.co.zw
W05	Stanbic Bank Zimbabwe	Zimbabwe	Commercial bank	Supplier finance replication	Victoria Falls	Head of Business Banking	stanbicbank.co.zw
W06	Infrastructure Development Bank of Zimbabwe (IDBZ)	Zimbabwe	DFI	Green finance (GCF accredited)	Harare	Head of Climate Finance	idbz.co.zw
W07	Zimbabwe Tourism Authority (ZTA)	Zimbabwe	Tourism board	Hub roundtable; licence rationalisation	Victoria Falls	Regional Manager	zimbabwetourism.net
W08	Zimbabwe Parks and Wildlife Management Authority (ZimParks)	Zimbabwe	Government	Concessions; KAZA NCU	Harare / Hwange / Victoria Falls	KAZA National Coordinator	zimparks.org.zw
W09	CAMPFIRE Association	Zimbabwe	CBNRM	Ward enterprises; community guarantee fund	Harare / Hwange and Binga RDCs	Director	to confirm
W10	Wild Horizons	Zimbabwe	Large operator	Anchor; supplier finance	Victoria Falls	Operations / Procurement Director	wildhorizons.co.za
W11	Africa Albida Tourism	Zimbabwe	Large operator	Anchor; local procurement	Victoria Falls	Sustainability / Community Lead	africaalbidatourism.com
W12	Tourism Business Council of Zimbabwe (TBCZ)	Zimbabwe	Industry association	Operator mobilisation; Compact	Harare / Victoria Falls chapter	Chief Executive Officer	to confirm
A01	Fundo de Garantia de Crédito (FGC)	Angola	Guarantee	KAZA guarantee window (Diversifica Mais model)	Luanda	Conselho de Administração / Director Comercial	to confirm
A02	Banco de Desenvolvimento de Angola (BDA)	Angola	DFI	On-lending lines	Luanda	Director de Crédito às PME	bda.ao
A03	Instituto Nacional de Apoio às MPME (INAPEM)	Angola	BSO	Delivery partner; MSME certification	Luanda / Menongue	Director Provincial Cubango	to confirm
A04	KixiCrédito	Angola	MFI	Micro lending; group loans	Menongue	Director Geral	to confirm
A05	Ministério do Turismo (MINTUR) / Okavango Tourism	Angola	Government	Tourism policy; licensing	Luanda / Menongue	Director Nacional de	to confirm

ID	Organisation	Country	Category	Role for the facility	Hub or office	Suggested contact point	Website
	Pole					Turismo	
A06	INBAC / Ministry of Environment	Angola	Government	Conservation areas; KAZA NCU	Luanda / Menongue	KAZA National Coordinator	to confirm
A07	Banco Sol / Banco BPC	Angola	Commercial bank	Partner lender with provincial footprint	Menongue	Director de Banca de Pequenos Negócios	to confirm
A08	The HALO Trust	Angola	NGO	Access and community engagement in Cuando and Cubango	Menongue	Angola Programme Manager	halotrust.org

Annex B. Sources

The sources were consulted in October 2026. Figures from the earlier *Financial Landscape Analysis* (GIZ Works repository, October 2026) carry that report's references.

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